

KF42 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Last week we started to learn the skill of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. This technique balances your autonomic nervous system, opens new brain paths, and clears your mind for rest or creative effort. It also relaxes your body and calms your emotions. You can read about this technique on the web and discover more of its great benefits. In our KF training, we practice this breathing method to focus our minds and explore our feelings about limitations.

In our last lesson we practiced **Alternate Nostril Breathing** guided by detailed instructions. In this lesson, however, less instruction will be offered so that you have more time to practice.

Alternate Nostril Breathing

Assume a meditation posture and breathe naturally for thirty seconds, allowing your body to regulate your breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, using your right hand, press your thumb against your right nostril, closing it off as you inhale. For the exhale, release your thumb and press your index or middle finger on your left nostril, exhaling through your right nostril. Inhale through your right nostril and then close it off, exhaling through your left nostril. Basically, you switch nostrils on the exhale. As you experiment with this technique, breathe naturally or use the **Three-Part Breath**. We will practice for three minutes. Begin. *(Pause for 3 minutes, announcing each minute as it passes)*

Pause. You might begin your meditation time with the **3-Minute Breathing Space** and then move to a few minutes of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**.

Our hymn for KF Confession 10 is *O Worship the King*. This hymn was written in 1833 by Sir Robert Grant, who served his country as a politician, CEO, lawyer, and governor.

O, worship the King all glorious above,
And gratefully sing His wonderful love!

Our Shield and Defender, the Ancient of Days,
Pavilioned in splendor and girded with praise.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

We begin to experience real liberty when we practice KF Confession 10:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

Here is a quote from *The Harvard Business Review*:

If success is a catalyst for failure because it leads to the ‘undisciplined pursuit of more,’ then one simple antidote is *the disciplined pursuit of less*. Not just haphazardly saying no, but purposefully, deliberately, and strategically eliminating the nonessentials. Not just once a year as part of a planning meeting, but constantly reducing, focusing and simplifying. Not just getting rid of the obvious time wasters, but being willing to cut out really terrific opportunities as well. Few appear to have the courage to live this principle, which may be why it differentiates successful people and organizations from the very successful ones.² (Pause)

In our culture, we think of ASAP as an acronym for ‘as soon as possible,’ implying an urgency that often overrides priorities and ignores the flow. In the last few lessons, I’ve encouraged you to think of ASAP in a new way: *Ask, Simplify, Adventure, and Prioritize*. Ask God for direction. Simplify your life like a soldier going into battle. Adventure into new territory that may threaten your Idol’s taboos. Set priorities that honor your discoveries. As the *Harvard Business Review* says, reduce, focus, and simplify for success. Get rid of the obvious time wasters in your life but, also, cut out the really terrific opportunities that do not support your priorities.

Really terrific opportunities can be dangerous; they tempt us to ignore our real limitations and waste our hard-won MATH. We then find ourselves committed to things that require money we don’t have, abilities we haven’t demonstrated, time that’s committed elsewhere, and a level of health that is not ours. We neglect our self-care, run on too little sleep, allow stress to build up, and drive ourselves back into slavery. If you find yourself regularly following this pattern, you might acknowledge the enslaving hold that your Idol has on you and then begin to tackle it with ASAP.

Realistic goals take into account the person you actually are and set priorities about what you will do with what you already have. Although you may be tempted to support your pride system with illusions of who you could be or what you would do with what you don’t have, your real business is to honor your limitations and rejoice in the truth of what you have to work with today. The truth of how capable you actually are is revealed in the evidence of how well you handle today. Handling today well requires firm priorities based on what you know about God, yourself, and your life.

Your resources are limited, and you will want to use them wisely. Wisdom includes recognizing the

limitation of cycles and the natural ebb and flow of the tide. The wisdom of simplicity budgets and allocates resources for those days when the tide goes out. If you build margins between your limitations and the normal, periodic drain of life's events, you will be able to make effective use of these inevitable low tides. Low tides are times to rest, restore, and establish a new working platform. In order to do that, we need to have stored resources.

As neurotics, we ignore or detest our actual limitations and impose on ourselves imagined limitations. Self-imposed limitations are the taboos that prevent us from exploring and changing our lives. These pseudo-limitations support the Idol's search for glory by focusing our energy on the achievement of idealized goals and, even worse, they prevent us from making courageous efforts toward developing the glory that is ours in Christ Jesus. The more we focus on our limitations, the less gratitude we feel. We look with secret envy at others who have what we want. We imagine that we are entitled to what we see and covet in their lives, and we judge it unfair that life has crippled us with limitations. We enviously compare our abilities to the perceived abilities of others, and these chronic comparisons perpetually remind us of our own poverty. We cannot be authentically grateful if we feel impoverished and chronically focus on what we don't have. As Idol worshipers, we have lost interest in our real assets, which in our eyes have no value simply because they are ours. We do not want to explore what is real about ourselves, because we are infatuated and blinded by our own ideas of what we should be. We actively limit ourselves because living within our self-imposed limitations feels safer than adventuring into the not-knowing. Imagined limitations are destructive. They lead to cravings, compulsive reactions, and greed, and they interfere with the circulation of true gifts, causing spiritual constipation and clogging up the circulation of the whole Creation. Greed cannot give freely. It can only give gifts begrudgingly and under compulsion and is always looking for a return. Greed causes us to snatch and clutch; it is always tense.

You only have one life here. What will you do with it? It is your business to budget the real resources that are yours. All human creatures have to consider their resources of money, abilities, time, and health. You only have so much money, so much training, so much time, and so much physical, mental, and emotional energy, or strength. Whenever you are faced with a decision, from the smallest thought about what to eat or wear to the larger issues of retirement planning or raising a child, do the MATH. M is for money. A is for abilities. T is for time. H is for health. Whenever you make plans for your life or hope to take on a new project or possibility, do the MATH.

To live gloriously you need to manage wisely the resources you have of money, ability, time, and health. These real resources are limited, and if you do not honor them by doing the MATH, areas of your life will become impoverished. This is a kind of energetic debt, and energetic debt causes anxiety. When we get into energetic debt, we are unable to generate gratitude; we feel deprived, and whatever energy we have is siphoned off into desperate and envious craving and snatching. If we overspend, we will accrue financial debt and envy those who have what we want. If we are beguiled by our imagined superiority, we get ourselves into situations that reveal our lack of ability. We then feel compelled to grab any praise, even if we don't deserve it. If we overschedule, we will resent anyone who takes our time or gets in our way. If we abuse our health, we will be forced to use valuable resources for recovery. If we ignore our physical, emotional, and spiritual health, our self-esteem and resilience will decline and create more limitations and more poverty.

When we ignore the limitations of our MATH and go into debt, our True Self can no longer flow in harmony with the Creation. We sense that we are falling behind, so we whip ourselves and others into performing, or we withdraw from active living to escape the strain of trying to keep up. That isn't a place of gratitude.

It is a place of fear and great vulnerability. When we engage in glorious living, however, we build on the rock of reality; we recognize that there are real limitations and that there is real potential.

In the next few weeks, we will learn to do the MATH and look at how limitations support gratitude and glorious living. This week, you might explore these questions in your **Flow Pages**: *In what direction do I want my life to go? Where is my money, ability, time, and health going today? Where am I in debt? What are my real limitations? What move toward my real glory would I like to make? What is my first priority?* Practice ASAP: Ask for help. Simplify your life. Adventure and explore. Then, once the truth about yourself and your situation is revealed, reshape your priorities.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, teach me to honor my real limitations and do the MATH. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 10 reminds us to make choices that will cultivate gratitude:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

In the Gospel of Luke, chapter 14, Jesus teaches us about limitations. He wants us to remember that we are just creatures with limited resources. It is our job to make the most of those resources, and that takes planning. Our text for this lesson, which I will read in my own paraphrase, is **Luke 14:25–33**. These verses speak about budgeting all of our limited resources.

²⁵Many people were going forward together with Jesus, and He turned to them and said,
²⁶"If anyone comes to Me to be My student and does not hate their own father and mother and wife and children and brothers and sisters, and even their own idealized life, that person is not yet able to become My student. ²⁷Whoever refuses to take their own cross into their own hands and come after Me does not yet have what it takes to be My student. ²⁸Look at it this way. Which of you, when you want to build a tower, does not first sit down and do the MATH to see if you have enough resources for its completion? ²⁹If you have laid a foundation but are unable to finish the tower because you did not do the MATH, everyone watching you will laugh at you, ³⁰saying, 'That idiot began to build and then did not have the resources to fulfill his plan!' ³¹Or, what king, when he sets out to meet another king in battle, will not first sit down and take counsel to determine whether he, with ten thousand men, has the MATH to encounter the one coming against him with twenty thousand men? ³²And if that king finds that he does not have the MATH, he prepares ahead for the possibilities and sends his senior ambassadors to the stronger king to ask for terms of peace. ³³So then, if you will not say goodbye to what you depend upon, you are not yet ready to be My student."

Take a deep breath.

Jesus is essentially talking about doing the MATH before seeking first the kingdom of God and His righteousness, but we can see in this passage that He wants us to consider our limitations in all of our undertakings.³ Are you willing to make God and His way of doing things your first priority? If you want to make Him your highest priority, then you have to set everything else and everyone else at a lower priority. That is what He means when He tells you that if you want to become His disciple, you must hate your own idealized life, your old family systems, your prideful illusions, and whatever you imagine you have control over or claim to own. You must also hate your community when it interferes with or actively opposes your priority to follow Jesus. You can imagine the shock of this teaching in a culture that had very strong personal feelings about family and possessions. Jesus isn't being selfish or harsh when He tells us to hate everyone close to us and give up our possessions. He is actually being kind by telling us the truth right from the beginning. If you choose to follow Jesus, your priorities will be tested. Jesus is simply reminding you that your resources are limited and that you will not fulfill your design if you allow yourself to be distracted by your Idol Self and your community. Without a strong sense of priority, someone or something will eventually turn you away from the path of orientation.

How and when you are distracted reveals the quality of your allegiance to God and your own trustworthiness. As your allegiance and trustworthiness grow, you will become more sensitive to the effects of misorientation and will learn to quickly recognize when you have disconnected from God and stepped out of the flow. That misoriented condition of strain and chaos will feel unnatural and destructive. You will begin to hate it. You will feel how vulnerable and uncomfortable it is to step out of peace and integrity. You can actually come to a place of hating a craving or a behavior that diverts you from your path to real glory. This is a healthy use of the emotion of hate.

Your Idol Self does not want to accept that you have real limitations. That's why this teaching is particularly distasteful and even painful for your Idol. Furthermore, the Idol Self hates the reality that as mortal creatures we spend most of our lives in simple maintenance—sleeping, eating and eliminating, caring for children, working, record keeping, commuting, and making repairs. Simple maintenance does not feel glorious, and the Idol craves feeling glorious. If we manage to please our families, build impressive towers, and win self-asserting battles, the Idol feels glorious, especially if we have gained these achievements through luck. Here is the uncomfortable truth that Jesus wants us to realize: real limitations require responsible actions, and responsible actions do not support our dreams of glory.

As neurotics, we refuse to plan around or even acknowledge our real limitations because we detest them. When we are faced with a limitation, we rush at it with both barrels blazing and without any real plan or preparation. Trying to overcome limitations by using force or denial exhausts our precious energy and inevitably leads to failure and deprivation, which then reinforces our belief that we are being cheated and undermined by an unfair world. Failure hurts our pride and fuels self-hate, and self-hate makes us shrink back from admitting the truth about ourselves. The fears generated by our hurt pride are very dangerous; they cut off our ability to respond to God. Sometimes, however, we prefer our fears to the challenge of becoming a weapon of orientation in this world. I once worked with someone who felt very helpless in the face of a perceived limitation. At the end of the session, he saw how he had invented the limitation to avoid expanding his potential in Christ.

Stubbornly resisting real limitations puts an unhealthy strain on every area of the MATH. When we resist the limitations of money, push beyond the limits of our abilities, overschedule, and abuse our bodies, we create anxiety and set ourselves up for failure. The self-contempt that we experience in our failures is really hurt pride. Our failures and self-deprecating feelings become our excuse for not pursuing our

potential, even when those failures and feelings have been generated by our own unwillingness to deal with real limitations.

Jesus encourages you to be wise and do the MATH before you explore any new possibility. He wants to support your success, so He reminds you that you are a creature with real limitations and must build your life on reality. Reality is the only secure place from which to set priorities and make decisions about your life. Jesus wants you to stop squandering your energy indulging grandiose ideas and start investing that same energy in learning to rejoice in the truth—in other words, in reality. Learn how to do your MATH. Assess your real money, abilities, time, and health. Then, based on the real evidence of your limited resources, plan your days to give yourself the best chance to build an increasingly courageous, glorious life that reveals the character of your Creator—a life that cannot be built on the magic of your imagined dreams. Say goodbye to your pride. Learn to assess your real limitations of money, abilities, time, and health. Then, in the light of that assessment, evaluate your projects. When faced with your real limitations, try gratitude. Those limitations can work for you. Present your puzzles to the Lord. Ask for direction. Simplify by humbly letting go of prideful illusions about yourself and your situation. Adventure into reality, and develop healthy priorities.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, teach me to do the MATH for my own life. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a limitation that seems restricting or unfair. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider a limitation that seems restricting or unfair*, how do you feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* If you are unaware of any feelings right now, you can observe your experience with compassion. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to simply rest in your awareness. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider a limitation that seems restricting or unfair*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider a limitation that seems restricting or unfair*. What sensations are there? Allow your body to talk to you. *(Pause)* You might say to yourself, “This is what discouragement feels like in my body” or “This is what frustration feels like.” You might feel relief in your body, or you might feel nothing at all. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this limitation that seems restricting or unfair*. Are you comfortable or uncomfortable while you observe? *(Pause)* Do you feel compelled to judge this limitation as good or evil? What do you believe about it? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Do you feel a similar restriction in other areas of your life? *(Pause)* Observe whatever you are experiencing as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath or the Dragon Breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore your limitations.
- Welcome the wise Holy Spirit of truth, who is training you to live in reality.
- Welcome where you are today and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what this limitation reveals. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁴

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I am trained by this limitation, I let go of the compulsion to have things go my way.
 - As I am trained by this limitation, I let go of the compulsion to fulfill my family system.
 - As I am trained by this limitation, I let go of the compulsion to defend what is mine.
 - As I am trained by this limitation, I let go of the compulsion to get my dreams magically fulfilled.
- (Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for drawing us together for this time of training and healing. Guide us by the power of our real limitations into the glory of our unique design. Teach us how to do the MATH for this week as we reorient our lives to flow more effectively in our karis relationships and to further our connection with our True Self and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *O Worship the King* by Sir Robert Grant (1779-1838), www.youtube.com/watch?v=RAyKmYD2Zg8.

² hbr.org/2012/08/the-disciplined-pursuit-of-less.

³ Matt. 6:33.

⁴ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.